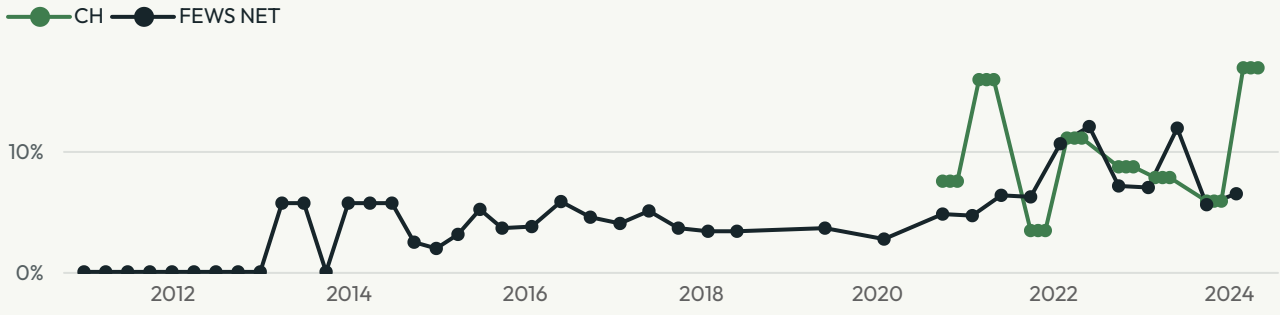
Hunger Hotspots and Blind Spots in Nigeria

1 | How serious is hunger, and how long has it lasted?

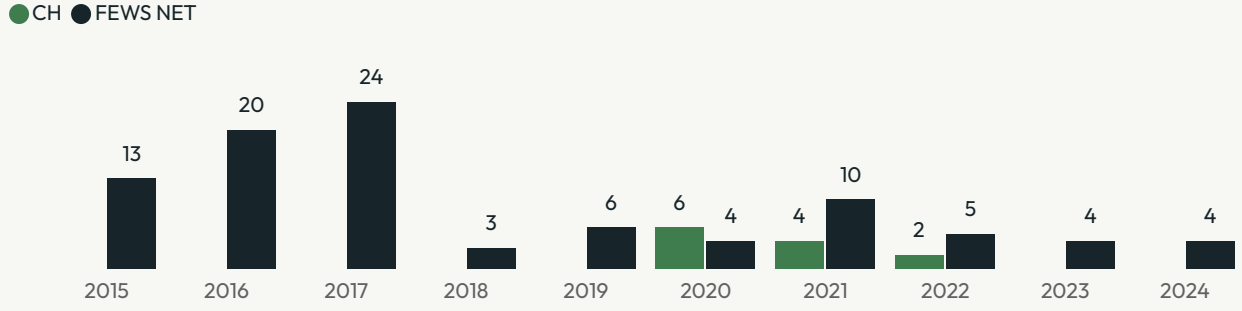
Crisis-level ratings peaked in mid-2022 (FEWS NET) and early 2024 (CH)

Share of assessed areas (LGAs) rated Phase 3 Crisis or worse, by assessment month



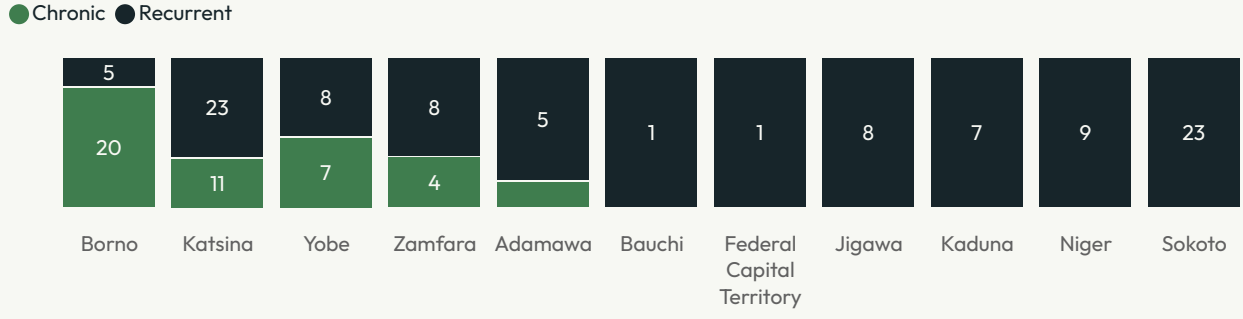
FEWS NET Emergency ratings peaked at 24 LGAs in 2017; CH recorded none after 2022

Number of LGAs rated Phase 4 (Emergency) each year



Borno and Katsina hold the most chronic hotspots (20 and 11 LGAs)

Chronic: rated Crisis or worse in half or more of CH assessments. Recurrent: sometimes, but less than half



Source: HFID, Joint Research Centre (European Commission), via the Humanitarian Data Exchange. LGA = Local Government Area. Phase 3+ = Crisis or worse. Shares count areas, not people.

Hunger Hotspots and Blind Spots in Nigeria (continued)

2 | Where is hunger concentrated?

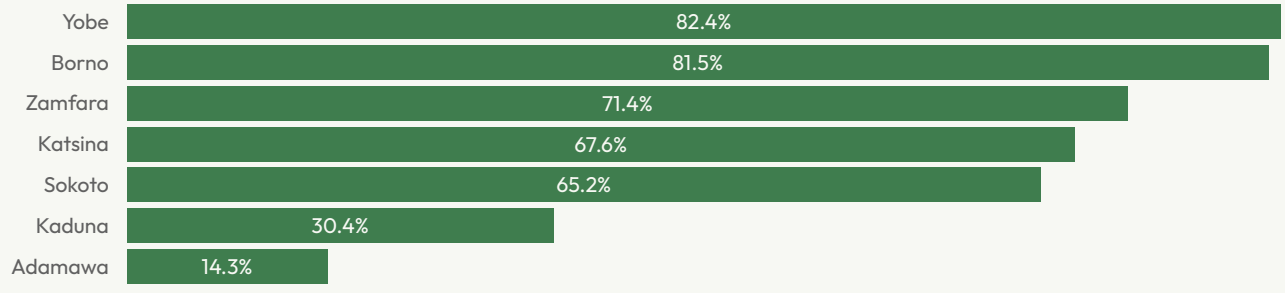
Crisis-level ratings were concentrated in the far north, March to May 2024

Share of assessed LGAs rated Crisis or worse. Darker green means a higher share. States in black were not assessed



Yobe and Borno had over 80% of assessed areas in Crisis or worse

Share of assessed LGAs rated Crisis or worse, March to May 2024. Top 7 states



The North East had the highest share every year; the North West rose sharply in 2024

Share of assessed LGAs rated Crisis or worse, by zone and year. 2020 and 2024 cover only part of the year

Zone	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024
North Central	1.4%	6.0%	0.0%	0.0%	0.0%
North East	23.0%	20.7%	21.2%	20.8%	35.7%
North West	0.0%	5.0%	14.2%	8.1%	29.6%
South East		0.0%	0.0%	0.0%	0.0%
South South		0.0%	0.0%	0.0%	0.0%
South West		0.0%	0.0%	0.0%	0.0%

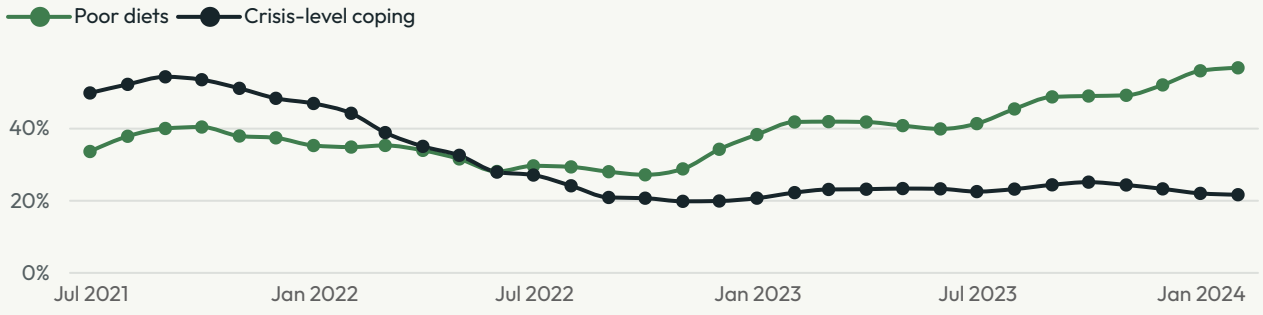
Source: HFID, Joint Research Centre (European Commission), via the Humanitarian Data Exchange. LGA = Local Government Area. Phases: 1 Minimal, 2 Stressed, 3 Crisis, 4 Emergency. 2020 and 2024 cover part of the year only.

Hunger Hotspots and Blind Spots in Nigeria (continued)

3 | What are households going through?

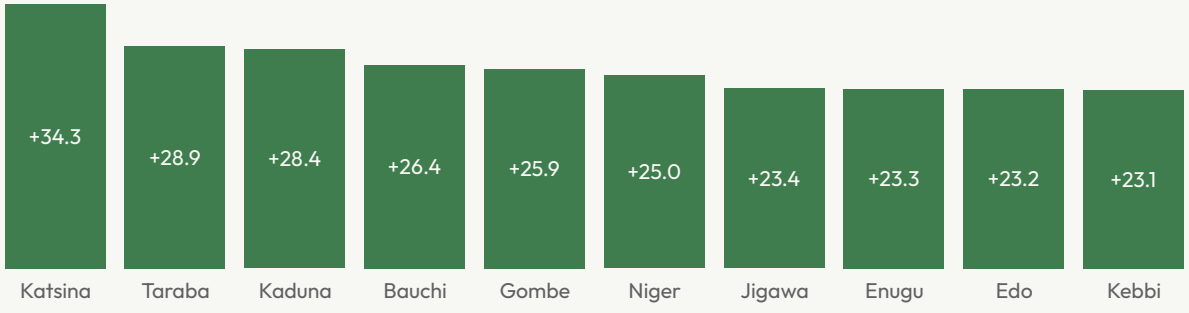
Poor diets reached highest level in early 2024, while crisis-level coping stayed well below 2021

Average share of people per state. Fewer states reported before late 2022, so early values compare less directly



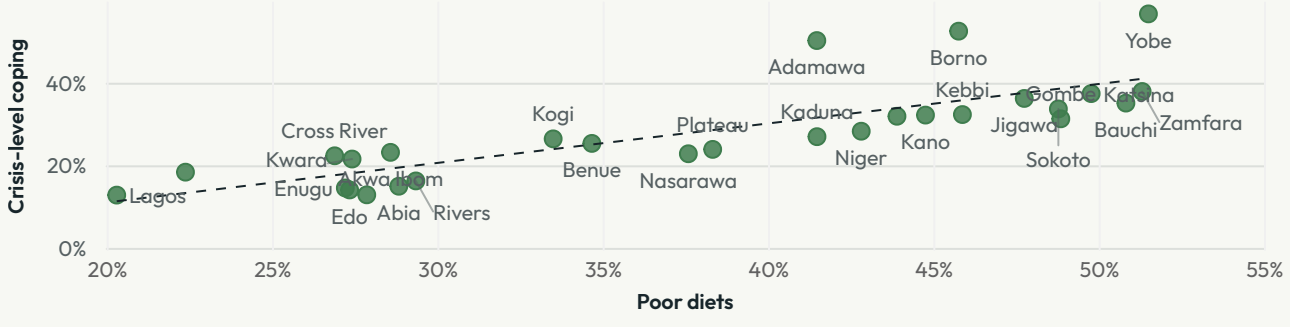
Katsina, Taraba and Kaduna saw the biggest rise in poor diets

Rise in share of people with poor diets, late 2022 to late 2023. +10 means, for example, 30% rising to 40%. Top 10 of 28 assessed states



States with poorer diets also tend to show more crisis-level coping

Each dot is a state, averaged over July 2021 to February 2024. The dashed line shows the overall trend



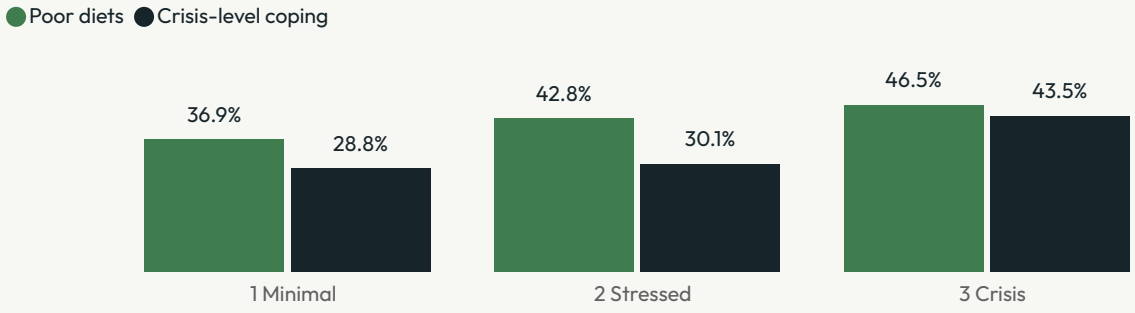
Source: HFID, Joint Research Centre (European Commission), via the Humanitarian Data Exchange. LGA = Local Government Area. Poor diets and crisis-level coping come from state-level household surveys.

Hunger Hotspots and Blind Spots in Nigeria (continued)

4 | Can we trust the data? Do the sources agree?

Higher CH ratings go with worse household results, though Phases 1 and 2 appear similar

Average share of people, by CH rating. Phase 4 is not shown because too few areas had survey data



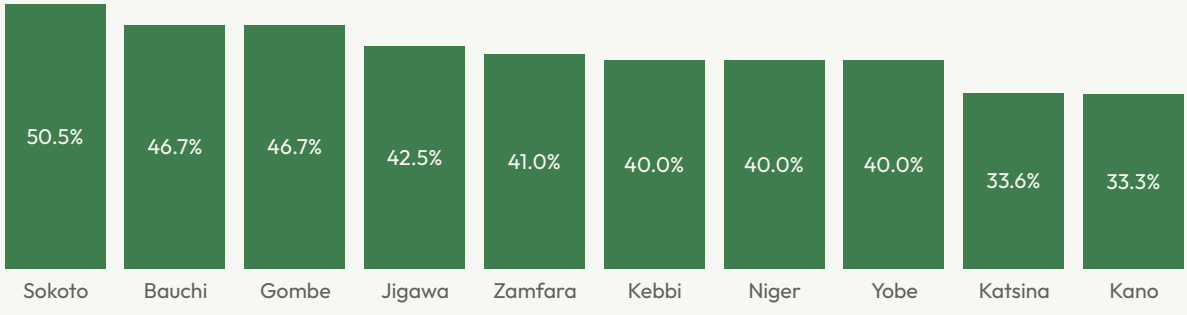
FEWS NET and CH often rate the same area differently, usually by one phase

Each cell counts LGAs rated by both, October 2020 to 2023. Cells where both ratings match (1 and 1, 2 and 2) are agreements

FEWS NET (rows) vs CH (columns)	1 Minimal	2 Stressed	3 Crisis	4 Emergency	**Total**
1 Minimal	454	326	3		**783**
2 Stressed	368	578	42		**988**
3 Crisis	14	91	63	3	**171**
4 Emergency			7	3	**10**
Total	**836**	**995**	**115**	**6**	**1952**

Sokoto, Bauchi and Gombe most often had poor diets in areas rated Minimal or Stressed

Share of times an area was rated Minimal or Stressed while at least half of people had poor diets. Top 10 states



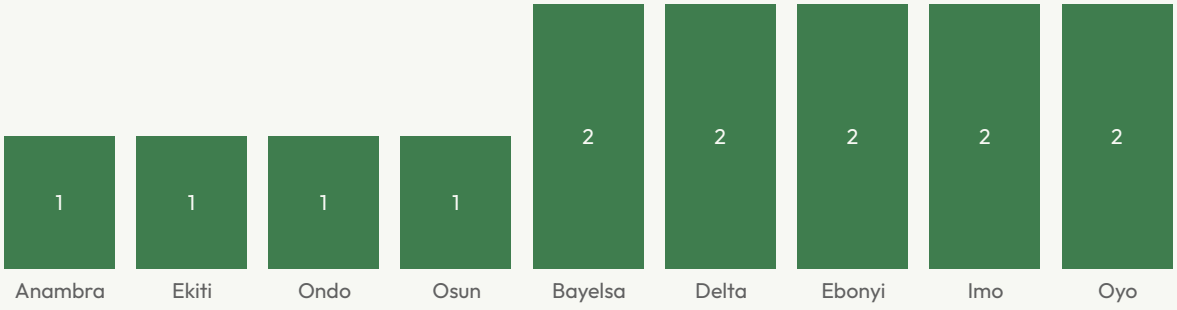
Source: HFID, Joint Research Centre (European Commission), via the Humanitarian Data Exchange. LGA = Local Government Area. FEWS NET and CH are separate expert rating systems.

Hunger Hotspots and Blind Spots in Nigeria (continued)

5 | Where are the gaps in the data?

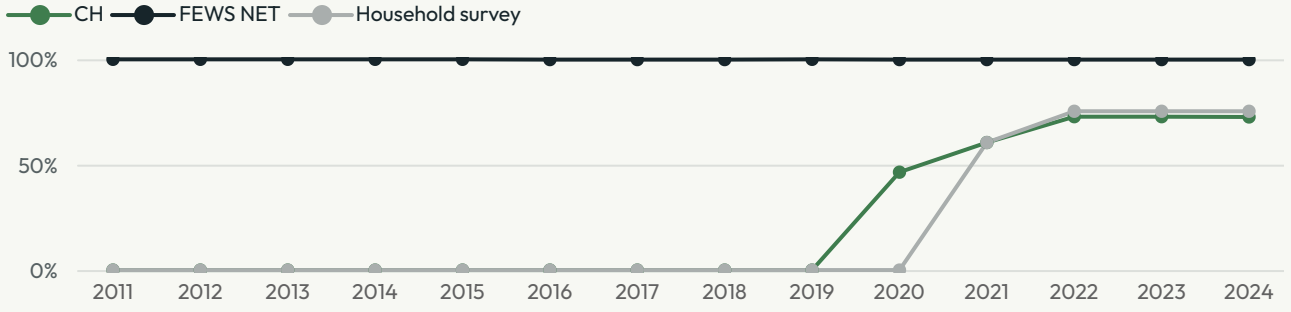
Nine states are missing at least one data source; four have only one

Number of sources (FEWS NET, CH, household survey) with any records for each state. States not listed have all three



CH and household surveys began in 2020 and 2021 and still cover only about three in four LGAs

Share of LGAs with at least one record from each source, by year



What the gaps mean

- Missing data does not mean there is no hunger. It means hunger in those places is harder to see and may go unreported.
- In the four states covered only by FEWS NET, there is no second rating and no household survey for a second opinion.
- Where only one source exists, decisions rest on a single view. Adding surveys or CH assessments would give a fuller picture.

Source: HFID, Joint Research Centre (European Commission), via the Humanitarian Data Exchange. LGA = Local Government Area. Coverage = share of LGAs with at least one record from that source.

Hunger Hotspots and Blind Spots in Nigeria (continued)

Summary | Key findings and what to do next

How serious, where, and what households report

43 chronic hotspot LGAs, rated Crisis or worse in half or more of their assessments.
31 are in Borno and Katsina, and one in four assessed LGAs has been in Crisis at least once.

82% of assessed LGAs in Yobe were rated Crisis or worse in March to May 2024, the highest of any state.
Borno was close behind at 81.5%.

57% of people had poor diets on average in February 2024, up from 27% in October 2022.

Can we trust the data?

56% of assessments rated by both FEWS NET and CH agree exactly.
Reading both gives a better picture.

22% of area-months rated Minimal or Stressed had poor diets for at least half of people.

9 states have no household survey data, and four of them also have no CH ratings.

What this suggests

1. Prioritise long-term support in chronic hotspots, mainly Borno, Katsina and Yobe, rather than only emergency response.

2. Close monitoring gaps, starting with the nine states that have no household survey data.

3. Conduct thorough assessments using multiple sources of data before deciding where to send help, because ratings and household data do not always agree.

Source: HFID, Joint Research Centre (European Commission), via the Humanitarian Data Exchange. LGA = Local Government Area. Descriptive analysis only. Prepared by Justice Chikesirim Obisike.